

“Make a Helm of Awe in lead, press the lead sign between the eyebrows, and speak the formula ... Thus a man could meet his enemies and be sure of victory.”

HEIMSKRINGLA, c. 1225



▲ Human sacrifice

A detail from one of the Stora Hammars picture stones in Gotland, Sweden, the center of this scene shows a small person lying face down on an altar, while a figure thought to be Odin brandishes a spear aloft. The magical *valknut* symbol of three interlocked triangles, associated with the transition from life to death, hovers over the prone figure.

As well as looking to sorceresses to foretell the future, the Norse people also searched for omens. Divination by lots was common: for example, if a fruit-tree branch was cut into tiny twigs and thrown randomly on a white cloth, it was said that the future could be read from the way the twigs fell.

The magic of nature

The Norse also used augury—the search for signs in nature. They thought that extreme natural events, such as storms and eclipses, could be messages from the gods, and that animals might carry messages, too. White horses were revered and kept in a sacred grove; when harnessed to a chariot left empty for the gods to drive, their path was said to reveal the gods’ will. The flight of birds such as crows, ravens, or eagles could also be taken as signs, and seeing a raven before a battle was a good omen. When Floki Vilgerderson, the first Norseman to deliberately sail to Iceland, set out in 867 he took three ravens as guides. Every so often he would release one raven, and plot his course according to which way the released bird flew.

Sacrifices

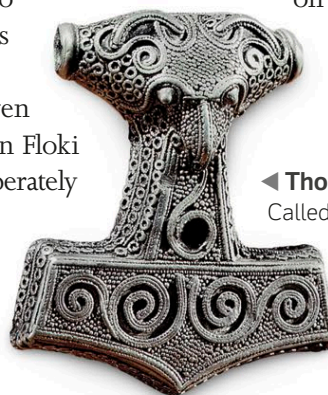
Keeping Odin and the other gods friendly was so important that the Norse made *blots* (sacrifices) to ensure that the deities stayed happy. Animals were ritually killed, and there is some evidence that the Norse people also made human sacrifices. In 1072, German monk Adam of Bremen wrote about a tradition of sacrifice at the temple to Thor, Odin, and Freyr at Uppsala in Sweden. He claimed that every nine years, nine males of every kind of living creature including humans were slaughtered in a holy grove near the temple, leaving the bodies hanging from the trees.

It was thought that such tales of human sacrifice might be Christian propaganda. However, an archaeological dig at Trelleborg, Sweden, uncovered the grim truth. In each of five wells, the skeletons of a human and animals were found together, with jewelry and tools. Four of the five human sacrifices were young children aged between four and seven.

Most sacrifices were less horrific. Rather than humans or animals, valuable jewels, tools, and weapons were cast into lakes: one hoard of such items was found in Tissø lake in Zealand, Denmark, a site sacred to the god Tyr.

The power of signs

Sigils (special symbols) had the same magic as spoken spells. They could be engraved on amulets or carved into particular woods and metals believed to have magical properties. Some sigils



◀ Thor's mighty Mjöllnir

Called Mjöllnir, Thor's hammer is depicted in this amulet with the god's staring eyes. The hammer is linked with the thunderbolt the god used to defend order. According to legend, Mjöllnir was capable of flattening mountains.